

THE UTILITY PLAYER

THE UTILITY PLAYER
IS A POSITION



BEING MOVED AROUND ISN'T A SIGN OF UNCERTAINTY. IT'S A SIGN OF TRUST.



THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

01

The Utility Player IS a Position

← You are here

02

The Mental Shift: From Extra to Essential

Coming up.

03

Training for Multiple Positions

Coming up.

04

When She Wants a Fixed Position

Coming up.

05

Utility Is Leadership: The Long Game

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

IF YOUR DAUGHTER DOESN'T HAVE A
FIXED POSITION AND THE COACH MOVES
HER AROUND, SHE HAS A POSITION. IT'S
CALLED UTILITY PLAYER, AND IT'S ONE OF
THE MOST TRUSTED ROLES ON THE TEAM.

A utility player is the Swiss Army knife of any team. The coach trusts her to go into any position at any time and perform consistently. That is not a placeholder role. That is the position.

— ADAPTABILITY IS A POSITION · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE UTILITY ROLE

THE COACH DOESN'T PUT AN ATHLETE IN MULTIPLE POSITIONS BECAUSE SHE DOESN'T KNOW WHERE SHE FITS. SHE DOES IT BECAUSE SHE TRUSTS HER EVERYWHERE.

- The utility player is the coach's secret weapon: adaptable, consistent, ready without ego
- She is trusted to enter at any moment, in any position, and perform
- That trust is earned, and it is a significant vote of confidence

— TRUST IN MULTIPLE POSITIONS IS THE HIGHEST COACHING ENDORSEMENT.

WHAT THE ROLE MEANS

ADAPTABLE

She can shift between positions without needing extra time or instruction. That's rare.

CONSISTENT

Her performance is reliable across positions, the coach can count on her wherever she goes in.

COACHABLE

She responds to role changes without ego or protest. That signal is worth more than the coach lets on.



06 · THE APPLICATION

OWNING THE ROLE

IN PRACTICE

Reframe from 'I don't have a position' to 'I'm trusted in multiple positions', this week, out loud.

WATCH FOR

Whether she approaches practices looking to lock into one position or build skills across several.

THE SHIFT

From measuring success by position specificity to measuring it by consistent readiness.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

COACHES DON'T GIVE RESPONSIBILITY
TO ATHLETES THEY DON'T TRUST. SHE
IS TRUSTED. OWN THAT.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, OWN THE UTILITY ROLE.

✓ Have your athlete say out loud: 'I'm trusted in multiple positions. That IS my position.'

✓ Identify one position she's been moved to that she's been approaching as an 'extra'

✓ Reframe: 'In this position, what does the team need from me specifically?'

✓ Track: does her engagement in that position change when she owns the role?



THE UTILITY PLAYER

THE MENTAL SHIFT:
FROM EXTRA TO
ESSENTIAL

02

THE REFRAME THAT CHANGES THE ROLE.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

AN ATHLETE WHO BELIEVES SHE IS
AN EXTRA PERFORMS LIKE AN
EXTRA. AN ATHLETE WHO BELIEVES
SHE IS ESSENTIAL PERFORMS
DIFFERENTLY.

The utility player role is only a liability if it is interpreted as not having a place. Reframed correctly, it is one of the most powerful roles on the team. The mental shift is the entire job.

— THE STORY YOU TELL ABOUT YOUR ROLE SHAPES HOW YOU PLAY IT · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE REFRAME

INSTEAD OF: 'I'M JUST FILLING IN.'
TRY: 'I'M ESSENTIAL WHEREVER THE
TEAM NEEDS ME MOST.'

→ 'I don't have a position.' → 'I'm trusted in multiple positions.'

→ 'I'm just an extra.' → 'I'm essential.'

→ 'I'm not important enough to specialize.' → 'My value is in my adaptability.'

— THE STORY SHE TELLS ABOUT HER ROLE IS THE PERFORMANCE SHE WILL GIVE.

THE TWO STORIES

THE VICTIM STORY

'They don't know what to do with me. I'm not good enough to have a real position.'

THE ESSENTIAL STORY

'I'm the one the coach trusts most to be ready anywhere, at any time.'

THE EVIDENCE

Both stories are available. The coach's behavior, putting her in multiple positions, supports the essential one.



INSTALLING THE NEW STORY

IN PRACTICE

Ask her: 'What does the team need from the utility player role that no one else can provide?'

WATCH FOR

Whether her body language when entering the game in different positions signals confidence or apology.

THE SHIFT

From entering apologetically to entering as the answer to whatever gap just opened.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

GIVE HER THE ESSENTIAL STORY, AND
WATCH HOW IT CHANGES THE PLAYER
WHO WALKS ONTO THE COURT.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, SWAP ONE STORY.

- ✓ Identify the specific story she's been telling about her utility role
- ✓ Work together to rewrite it using the essential framework
- ✓ Have her say the new story out loud before the next practice
- ✓ Notice: does her performance in the role change when the story changes?



THE UTILITY PLAYER

TRAINING FOR MULTIPLE POSITIONS

03

THE UTILITY PLAYER DOESN'T SPECIALIZE. SHE BROADENS — AND THAT IS THE COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

IN PRACTICE, THE UTILITY PLAYER SHOULD NOT BE LOOKING TO LOCK INTO ONE POSITION. SHE SHOULD BE LOOKING FOR OPPORTUNITIES TO BUILD COMPETENCE IN EVERY POSITION SHE PLAYS.

This is not a limitation, it is a leadership development path. The athlete who can play three positions well has three times the opportunity to contribute. That is not a smaller life. It is a bigger one.

— BREADTH IS LEADERSHIP · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE BREADTH ADVANTAGE

**SPECIALIZATION CREATES DEPTH. UTILITY
CREATES LEADERSHIP. BOTH ARE VALUABLE.
KNOW WHICH YOU ARE BUILDING.**

- In practice: look for reps in every position you play, not just the most comfortable one
- Build competence metrics across positions: what needs to improve in each role?
- The athlete who is great in multiple positions is the one who makes the roster in tight decisions

— BREADTH IS NOT A CONSOLATION PRIZE. IT IS A DIFFERENT KIND OF EXCELLENCE.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

THE TRAINING MINDSET

SPECIALIZATION MINDSET

'I need to lock in my libero game.': Valid, if that's the role.

UTILITY MINDSET

'What do I need to do as an outside hitter that makes me reliable there too?': Broader, more flexible.

THE TOOL

Maintain a position-by-position development list: what is the one skill to improve in each role?



THE POSITIONMAP

IN PRACTICE

Create a position map: list every position she plays and one development goal for each.

WATCH FOR

Whether she approaches different positions with equal curiosity or obvious preference.

THE SHIFT

From hoping to get settled in one spot to actively developing value in every spot she plays.

02

07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE ATHLETE WHO IS EXCELLENT IN
ONE POSITION IS VALUABLE. THE ONE
WHO IS RELIABLE IN MANY IS
ESSENTIAL.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, BUILD THE POSITION MAP.

- ✓ List every position she has been asked to play this season
- ✓ For each one, identify: 'What is the one skill I need to build here?'
- ✓ Prioritize the one with the biggest gap and build a mini-plan for it
- ✓ Connect each position goal to her 12-week arc



THE UTILITY PLAYER

WHEN SHE WANTS
A FIXED POSITION



THE DESIRE TO SPECIALIZE IS VALID. HERE'S HOW TO NAVIGATE IT WITHOUT LOSING THE ROLE.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

THE UTILITY PLAYER OFTEN WANTS
NOTHING MORE THAN A FIXED
POSITION. THAT DESIRE IS VALID,
AND IT DOESN'T MEAN SHE'S WRONG
TO WANT IT.

The goal is not to convince her to love the utility role forever. The goal is to help her excel in it now, and build the skills that give her a clear path to a specialized role if that's where she is headed.

— WANTING SPECIALIZATION IS VALID. STAYING EXCELLENT IN UTILITY IS THE PATH. · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE HONEST NAVIGATION

ACKNOWLEDGE WHAT SHE WANTS.
THEN BUILD THE PATH TO IT, THROUGH
THE ROLE SHE HAS NOW.

- Validate the desire: wanting a fixed role is not weakness, it's a clarity about preferences
- Name the path: excellence in the utility role builds the trust that earns the specialized one
- Set the goal: what does she need to demonstrate in order to be considered for a specific position?

— THE PATH TO WHERE SHE WANTS TO GO RUNS THROUGH WHERE SHE IS NOW.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

THE H O N E S T C O N V E R S A T I O N

WHAT SHE WANTS

A fixed role, clarity about her position, the identity of being 'the libero' or 'the outside.'

WHAT THE COACH SEES

A reliable, adaptable athlete who hasn't demonstrated enough position-specific excellence yet.

THE BRIDGE

What would she need to demonstrate in one specific position to make the case for it?



THE PATH CONVERSATION

IN PRACTICE

Encourage her to ask the coach: 'Is there a specific position you see me developing most toward?'

WATCH FOR

Whether the coach's answer reveals a development pathway or confirms the utility role as long-term.

THE SHIFT

From hoping the coach notices her preference to actively building the case through her performance.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE FIXED POSITION SHE WANTS IS
AVAILABLE. THE PATH THERE RUNS
THROUGH EXCELLENCE IN THE ROLE
SHE HAS.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, HAVE THE HONEST CONVERSATION.

- ✓ Ask: 'Is there a position you're most interested in specializing in?'
- ✓ Help her identify what she needs to demonstrate there to make the case
- ✓ Encourage her to ask the coach, in the right moment, about her development trajectory
- ✓ Build the position goal into her 12-week arc



THE UTILITY PLAYER

UTILITY IS LEADERSHIP:
THE LONG GAME



THE ATHLETE WHO CAN PLAY ANYWHERE BECOMES THE LEADER WHO CAN DO ANYTHING.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

THE UTILITY PLAYER ROLE IS
TEMPORARY IN VOLLEYBALL, BUT
THE SKILL IT BUILDS IS
PERMANENT.

Adaptability, reliability, ego-free service to the team's needs — these are leadership characteristics that will define your athlete's ceiling in every domain she enters. The utility role, played well, is leadership training at the highest level.

THE LEADERSHIP TRANSFER

THE ATHLETE WHO KNOWS HOW TO SHOW UP WHEREVER THE TEAM NEEDS HER BECOMES THE ADULT WHO LEADS IN EVERY ROOM SHE ENTERS.

- Adaptability: the ability to perform in changing conditions without complaint
- Reliability: the team can count on her regardless of the context
- Ego-free service: the willingness to do what's needed, not just what's recognized

— LEADERSHIP LOOKS A LOT LIKE UTILITY. HELP HER SEE THE CONNECTION.

T H E T R A N S F E R

WORKPLACE

The professional who can be deployed in any role, on any project, without ego: is indispensable.



LEADERSHIP

The leader who meets the team's need rather than her own visibility sets the culture for everyone else.

RELATIONSHIPS

The person who shows up wherever she is needed, consistently and without drama, is irreplaceable.



NAMING THE TRANSFER

IN PRACTICE

After a match where she played multiple positions well, name the leadership skill she demonstrated.

WATCH FOR

Whether she is beginning to see the role as a strength rather than a compromise.

THE SHIFT

From managing the disappointment of not having a fixed position to celebrating the leadership it requires.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE UTILITY PLAYER WHO PLAYS HER
ROLE WITH EXCELLENCE IS BUILDING
THE LEADERSHIP CHARACTER THAT
WILL DEFINE HER ENTIRE LIFE.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, NAME ONE LEADERSHIP SKILL THE UTILITY ROLE BUILT.

- ✓ After her next match, identify one moment where her utility role required real leadership
- ✓ Name it explicitly: 'What you just did, showing up in a role you didn't expect, that's leadership.'
- ✓ Connect it to a future context: 'That's the same thing you'll do in a job when things change suddenly.'
- ✓ Celebrate the character, not just the game

